

SHARE WIFE SAVE LAND

It may be incongruous in the 21st century, but polyandry, an ancient tribal custom in the remote Kinnaur district of Himachal Pradesh, still thrives. The reasons are largely to do with ancestral land holdings and preserving their economic sustenance.

■ By Ramesh Vinayak in Kinnaur

Ranjit Singh, 33, and Chander Prakash, 30, are brothers who live in Sangla Valley in Himachal Pradesh. They share a close bond but that's not the only thing: they also share a wife. As do other members of their family and other locals in this picture-postcard beautiful apple-growing area, some 200-km from Shimla in the mountainous Kinnaur district of Himachal Pradesh. Sangla is a favourite destination for honeymooning couples who find inspiration from the romantic surroundings—but even more from the local women. Sunita Devi, 28, is the petite woman Ranjit and Chander are both married to and five years after she plunged into polyandry—illegal as per law—she is the picture of wedded bliss. “I am lucky to have the affection of two husbands,” says the mother of two daughters, shyly glancing at her spouses. They live in Boning Saring, a quaint cluster of dwellings amidst apple orchards on the edge of river Baspa.

Outsiders may feel uncomfortable coming face to face with a custom that is not just outlawed but seems out of place in the 21st century but Ranjit, a part-time postman, and Chander, who runs a grocery shop, do not feel uncomfortable about sharing a wife. Nor, in fact, do the 15-odd other families in the hamlet who actually take pride in up-

holding the ancestral custom. Their elder brothers—Amarjit Singh and Sovan Singh—both have a common wife. In fact, all four siblings had a single mother and two fathers. They are emblematic of the polyandrous tradition still in vogue in the tribal territory of Kinnaur.

Though steeped in antiquity and local mythology profoundly imbued with the Mahabharata legend of five Pandava brothers sharing wife Draupadi, brothers married to one woman is seen as the best way to prevent division of ancestral agricultural lands. Though there are no cases of female foeticide, the district has a skewed sex ratio, with 857 girls for every 1,000 boys—another factor favouring polyandry. It has also been a socially-mandated tribal practice to facilitate economic sustenance. Take, for instance, the case of Tashi Tsering, 65, and Namgayal Tsering, 62, the ironsmith brothers in Katgaon hamlet in the

Bhaba Valley, who have been sharing a wife in 60-year-old Karam Dasi for the past three decades. With four common offspring, they eke out their living mainly from the four bighas of land they had inherited. “Had we married separately,

BROTHERS NAMGAYAL TSERING (L) AND TASHI TSERING (R) WITH THEIR WIFE KARAM DASİ (C), KATGAON, BABHA VALLEY IN KINNAUR DISTRICT

With four common offspring, they eke out their living mainly from the four bighas of land they had inherited. They feel having a common wife has saved them from penury.



Photographs by REUBEN SINGH

